Tayyip Erdoğan, pairing his message with a handshake photo to convey cooperation and respect.[11] Similarly, after Donald Trump repeatedly criticized the UN, Secretary-General António Guterres tweeted a personal message wishing Trump a speedy recovery from COVID-19, signaling goodwill despite political tensions.[12]

Third, IOs can reframe potential constraints placed on members as benefits. In doing so, IOs can reposition their policies to appeal to citizens by framing them as tools to hold elites accountable. For example, conditions attached to IMF loans could be presented as measures targeting corruption or ensuring elite contributions to social welfare (e.g., the IMF's efforts to emphasize the need for the wealthy to pay their taxes during the eurocrisis). By shifting the focus away from restrictions on sovereignty and toward benefits for citizens, IOs can mitigate perceptions of overreach.

We thus derive two main expectations from this framework. First, we expect that IOs' populist-style messages on social media generate more public engagement (measured with likes and retweets) than traditional, technocratic messaging. Second, we expect that ordinary citizens exposed to populist-style IO messaging will express greater support for IOs compared with those receiving technocratic or neutral messaging. To test these hypotheses, we analyze a large dataset of IOs' social media communications and conduct an original survey experiment to evaluate the effectiveness of various rhetorical strategies. The results shed light on how IOs adapt to counter populist resistance and shape public sentiment in an increasingly polarized global landscape.

7.4 Empirical Analysis: Testing IOs' Populist-Style Communications

We investigate whether IOs adopt populist-style communication strategies on social media and evaluate the public's response to such messaging. Our analysis comprises two key empirical tests. First, we assess whether populist-style tweets from IOs and their leaders generate higher public engagement, measured by likes and retweets, compared with other types of tweets. We then turn to an original survey experiment that examines whether publics approve more highly of IOs that issue populist-style rhetoric than